Session 4

2025-02-16

1 – Briefing at the keep

~14:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. After roughly ten hours of sleep, the party is awake at the Greenest keep in the early afternoon. The town is in the daylight clean-up: surviving guards bandaged and overworked, dead bodies being gathered to be cremated that night to avoid disease. The party's purses are empty.
2. **Tarbaw Nighthill** and **Escobert the Red** gather the party in a side room. The castellan reports the captured cultist did not survive his interrogation — Escobert's knuckles are bloodied and split. One of the party murmurs that Escobert's hand clearly slipped.
3. Tarbaw lays out what the keep needs: motivations of the raiders, leaders, numbers, and plans, so the next likely target can be warned. As a bonus, recover any of the looted treasure if possible. He offers **200 gp per head** if the party can bring back this intel.
4. The party is hailed as the heroes of Greenest; soldiers salute them in the corridors. Mialee asks Eguzkilore in a side conversation whether they should show Tarbaw the cult map; the party agrees, and Eguzkilore produces it.
5. Tarbaw studies the map. The X marked south of Greenfields corresponds to a hilly area roughly 12 miles south, about four hours' march. The terrain transitions from rolling farmland into rougher hills with caves, sparse herd-pasture and no settled villages. A plausible cult hideout.
6. The party discusses tactics: not an assault, a *reconnaissance*. Approach, observe numbers and disposition, withdraw with intel.
7. Mialee broaches the leadership question. Nyx assumes Langdedrosa Cyanwrath is the leader; Tarbaw corrects her — survivors describe a human who was directing operations, and Langdedrosa is too exposed to be the actual head.
8. Nyx then asks whether Langdedrosa might in fact be the *"Mujer Dragón"* the kobolds had named the night before. Tarbaw corrects the conflation: Langdedrosa is male, and a Half-Dragon rather than a true dragon.
9. Sinsong asks whether any of the keep guards could come along. Tarbaw answers carefully: the keep cannot spare anyone, but the guards are free citizens — the party can try recruiting one from the wounded. Tarbaw walks them to the infirmary.

2 – Recruiting help

1. The infirmary is full of wounded guards in varying states. Sinsong announces, half in earnest and half theatrical, that he wants to hire a guard for the mission. Nuberroca quips that the more dying, the cheaper.
2. ***[EPIC]*** Sinsong delivers a recruitment speech to the room: *"Si alguien está dispuesto a venir con nosotros a una lucha que desde luego marcará el futuro de Greenest y de la gente que vive en ella, no descansando desde una cama sino luchando espada contra espada, que levante la mano si es que le queda."* The speech lands on the room because the party's reputation precedes them; even **Tarbaw** quietly acknowledges that no one in the keep is in shape to come.
3. One badly wounded guard half-rises and says he would go, but only if the party can guarantee his family's wellbeing should he not return. He names a figure: roughly fifty gold pieces. The party's pockets are empty — between the six of them, two platinum and five gold, which the guard cannot accept.
4. Sinsong improvises: he tries to pawn his own mace as a sanctified relic of the heroes of Greenest — the guard appreciates the gesture but says a mace cannot feed his children.
5. The party pivots: is there a wounded guard with no family attached? Someone with nothing to lose. Mialee suggests, only half-joking, taking an unconscious one and not waking him until they are far down the road.
6. Sinsong walks back through the cots and finds an unconscious guard with no family. He casts Healing Word on him — barely enough to wake him. The man stirs, dazed, head ringing. Sinsong's bald head glows during the cast; the man notices but is too weakened to ask about it.
7. Nyx pulls a bottle from her own kit, opens it, and starts pouring drinks for the surrounding wounded while the guard wakes — *"tomad, tomad, que tenéis que recuperaros."*
8. The man names himself **Miguel**. The party explains the mission and asks him to come along. Miguel is reluctant — he is barely standing, the keep needs him, the wounded need him — but agrees in the end on one condition: he comes as a guide and lookout, not as a fighter, and the party does not put him in harm's way. The party accepts.
9. Miguel tells them he needs a moment to ready himself and will catch up at the gate.

3 - A monk's apprentice

1. As the party readies to depart, a young half-elf approaches, limping. He introduces himself as **Nesim Waladra**, the apprentice of a monk named **Leosin Erlanthar**. Leosin and his companions have been investigating the *Cult of the Dragon* for months — the cult's activity has increased dramatically — and were tracking the raiders into the area when they were intercepted last night outside Greenest.
2. The apprentice and the others escaped; Leosin did not return. They cannot tell whether he was killed, captured, or chose to infiltrate. The latter would not surprise them — Leosin is reckless that way.
3. He shows the party Leosin's pendant: a leather cord with a silver fitting in the shape of a silver dragon. Nesim names the symbol as Bahamut, the dragon god; Mialee recognizes it — counterpart to the Tiamat insignia the party already carries. The leather is torn at the back — not removed by Leosin, *ripped from him*.
4. The apprentice tells them the Cult of the Dragon is enormous — several thousand, possibly hundreds of thousands, of members across the Sword Coast. He cannot guess at numbers locally. One of their fellow monks has already departed to Berdusk seeking reinforcements; help, if it comes, is days away.
5. He asks the party to look for Leosin and bring him, or any news, back. Leosin is described as a half-elf with no particular distinguishing features, his only distinctive carry being his now-broken staff and the pendant the apprentice still holds.
6. The party agrees and Nesim leaves, limping, towards the infirmary.

4 - Tracking the raiders

~14:30, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party leaves Greenest with Miguel as guide, headed south. Outside town the trail is plain: a wide swath of trampled grass through cultivated fields, the path of several hundred attackers retreating toward their hideout.
2. Nyx and Mialee read the prints — booted humans, clawed kobold feet, and a third set of larger four-legged tracks: the drakes seen in the assault on Greenest, used here as pack beasts.
3. Crucially, both inbound and return prints are visible, and the drakes' return prints are noticeably deeper than the inbound ones — laden coming back, with looted goods. No cart wheels: everything they took, they put on the drakes.
4. The estimated raider strength is not 100, nor 200, it's closer to **400 or half a thousand**, possibly more.
5. The terrain turns slowly — first farmland, then scattered low knolls, then progressively steeper hills. The party advances cautiously, watching for stragglers, ambushes, or rearguards.

5 - The stragglers fire

~16:30, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Roughly two hours into the trek, a thin column of smoke catches the party's eye, rising between rocks ahead — a small cooking fire, not a signal fire.
2. Mia and Nyx scout in close. Eguzkilore and Nuberroca close in covered by the rocks, but unable to see the cultists. Miguel hides with the party's gear at the rear.
3. From cover Mialee makes out the camp: four human cultists eating rabbit they have cooked, weapons stacked together against a single rock. Apart from them, around ten kobolds eating their own scraps, *ostracized* — taking insults from the humans and visibly enduring them rather than answering. The kobolds wear their weapons on their belts; the humans do not.
4. Nyx sends Eguzkilore a Message cantrip describing what they see and asking for his read. Eguzkilore likes the idea of stealing the swords — disarmed, the cultists might even turn the blame on the kobolds and start a fight.
5. The party regroups and the scouts brief them in cover. Mialee proposes attacking, but only after stealing the four swords first. Nyx remains uneasy — they are five against fourteen at best, and yesterday smaller groups gave them serious trouble.
6. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee creeps in. With the cultists' backs turned and arguing about the cook's handling of the rabbit, she slips behind their rock. Once in position, she casts Minor Illusion behind the cultists — the rustle of something snake-like in the brush. The nearest cultist startles, the rest crane around to look, and Mialee uses the diversion to lift all four swords cleanly off the rock and slip back to cover.
7. With the swords secure, Nyx whispers across to Mia asking if any cultist is watching her direction; the answer is no, they are still focused on the rabbit. Nyx Messages Nuberroca, identifying herself and giving the green light to attack. Hearing the disembodied voice in his head, Nuberroca panics briefly and asks Eguzkilore if he heard it too — Eguzkilore tells him it is in his head and to move.

6 - A swift ambush

1. Nyx fires from cover; the arrow strikes hard but the cultist holds, dropping his food in shock. One of the others jokes that what hurts him most is losing the food.
2. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca leaps from the rocks above with a war-cry, reaching the cultist and landing an axe-blow that takes a cultist's head off cleanly, then a second slash that splits another cultist *almost in half*. Pieces of cultist and pieces of cooked rabbit land together on the camp.
3. Eguzkilore runs down behind Nuberroca, takes cover behind a tree, and ends another cultist with a longbow shot.
4. Two winged kobolds break from the camp into the air; the rest of the kobolds dive into cover behind rocks and start hurling stones with slings. The kobolds' positioning behind the rocks is good enough that the party's return arrows mostly clatter off stone.
5. A winged kobold dives over Nuberroca and drops a stone from above; the throw lands hard, catching the goliath in the head for a severe hit.
6. The kobolds' stone volleys keep landing brutally one after the other. Mialee takes a stone in the kidney from one of them, badly wounded.
7. Mia uses her action to drink a healing potion, then ducks fully out of sight behind her rock.
8. A faint *blue glow* flickers along the gash above Nuberroca's brow; the cut closes enough for him to wipe the blood out of his eye and keep moving.
9. The rogue asks the party to keep the last cultist alive. Nuberroca gets the message. He moves up, grapples the surviving cultist, and clocks him into unconsciousness with a single open-handed blow rather than the axe, then carries the limp body back tucked under one arm.
10. Nyx fires on the wounded winged kobold; the arrow clips its wing, dropping it grounded but alive. It slips off into the rocks.
11. The other winged kobold flies away over the cliffs to the north, taking a final volley from Eguzkilore that misses. Several of the ground kobolds break and flee in the same direction — at least six retreating uphill. The remaining few are killed.
12. Eguzkilore tracks the wounded winged kobold by its blood trail; it dies a few yards on. He searches the body and finds a stone pendant on a cord around its neck — mundane junk, but he keeps it. He returns to the party and gives it to Nuberroca as a gift after Nuberroca shares the rum bottle he has just looted from a cultist's pouch.
13. Nuberroca takes a swig from the rum, beams, and offers the bottle to Eguzkilore: *"esto está increíble, es como el azúcar ese, está buenísimo esto."* The elf takes a small sip, only enough to be polite. They are still standing among the bodies of the cultists when the toast happens.

7 - Interrogation

1. The captured cultist is bound with Eguzkilore's rope. Nuberroca pees on him in lieu of water to wake him; Mialee searches him while he is out. He carries a bell, a hooded lantern, leather armor — nothing of obvious value.
2. The cultist comes to. Mialee tries to lead the interrogation but botches her opening — Nuberroca steps in, then breaks one of the cultist's fingers when threats fail. The cultist gasps but does not yield.
3. Mialee dangles ten gold pieces in front of him. The cultist refuses with *"el destino solo lo decide Tiamat. Estoy preparado para morir."*
4. Nuberroca cycles through tactics — *"¿quieres que te vuelva a orinar en la boca?"*, then he begins fileting one of the dead cultists in front of him as additional intimidation. The prisoner responds with cult dogma: *"el mundo debe ser dirigido por los mejores, que son los dragones"*.
5. Asked whether he knows **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath**, the cultist answers only that his lips are sealed.
6. Nuberroca raises the axe over the prisoner's neck and gives the rest of the party one last chance to call it off. Eguzkilore, audibly, bounces the call back to Nuberroca and tells him to decide for himself. Mialee hesitates, then proposes **Miguel** take the prisoner back to Greenest so **Escobert** can try with proper tools — better than executing a defenseless man.
7. Eguzkilore searches the prisoner one last time and confirms he carries no hidden blades. Miguel agrees to escort the prisoner back; the party hands him the rope and tells him to keep his spear at the prisoner's back. The guard leaves north toward Greenest with the bound cultist.
8. Nuberroca grumbles aloud that he does not understand letting a defeated combatant survive to be enslaved, but the party moves on. The path ahead is plain even without Miguel as guide.

8 - The defile pass

~18:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. About one and a half hours further south, the party enters a narrowing defile: large rocks, the path serpentining between cliffs. Most of the surrounding hills are sheer and unscalable; only a few ridges, eroded enough for a person to climb, give access overhead.
2. The footprints in the dust grow distinctly fresher. Eguzkilore notes there are no horse tracks — only the drakes seen earlier — meaning whatever defenders are ahead, no cavalry has reinforced them.
3. Roughly half an hour from the X marked on the map, the party is well into the rocky stretch when stones begin to rumble overhead. Several boulders come down on them: Nuberroca and Nyx are surprised and get slammed; Mialee and Eguzkilore dodge the worst but still take a glancing hit.
4. A *soft blue glow* ripples briefly along the bruise the boulder left on Nuberroca's ribs; the worst of the ache eases before he can plant his feet.
5. From the ridges above, the party makes out the ambush party of cultists in matching black leather livery — different from yesterday's mob — plus two acolytes and one veteran clearly better-armored and better-armed than the rest. The veteran trains his crossbow on Nuberroca, marking the goliath as his target.
6. The party is exhausted from the camp fight, outnumbered, in the lower ground, and freshly wounded. Mialee is the first to call it — they can still flee — and Eguzkilore agrees: get out before the rest commit. Nuberroca scoops Mialee and Nyx, one under each arm, and dashes back the way they came. Eguzkilore dashes after them.
7. The veteran above raises his heavy crossbow and looses at the retreating barbarian — the bolt buries itself in the dirt at his feet. Spears and javelins fall short at that range.
8. As the party flees, an alarm-call goes up from the defile — a horn note. One cultist breaks south at a sprint along the path toward the cult camp ahead. *Whoever is at the X knows the party exists now.*
9. About a mile back from the defile, in country open enough to choose a hide and rough enough to break their tracks in, the party stops. They erase their trail and go to ground in cover.
10. Half an hour later, no pursuit reaches them. The party debates options — wait until nightfall to push back in under cover of dark, or pull all the way back to Greenest.